communists, was to ask China to supply arms to Pakistan as Brown found it difficult to convince the US Congress to remove the embargo on arms supplies to Rawalpindi. In this context, Afghanistan was in safe hands according to the CPI, and it was time for India to look after itself. Some communist leaders even went ahead to equate, erroneously, the Soviet intervention in Afghanistan with the Indian intervention in erstwhile East Pakistan in 1971. Other left-wing politicians such as Chitta Basu of the Forward Bloc, which was in an alliance with the CPM in West Bengal, urged the Indian government to train its guns towards the US, China, and Pakistan.

Gandhi's complicated balancing act was a 'policy compromise' in light of fiercely contesting advocacies of the supporters and detractors of the Soviet intervention. The trajectory of her policy response was both a cause and consequence of competing policy advocacies within India and abroad. It was a 'yes, but' approach in which New Delhi supported Moscow's Afghan endeavors, but only reluctantly. In praxis, India was never able to, and arguably could never have, effectively resolved the contradictions generated by the Soviet intervention. Whatever policy Gandhi would have adopted, it would have had its critics and supporters. Moreover, India's official stand to deal with whichever government was de facto in power in Kabul in 1980, was as much a sign of commitment to Afghanistan as it was a symbol of Kabul's inconsequence in New Delhi. Driven by Cold War politics, the real debate was around India's relationship with the Soviet Union and not Afghanistan. Kabul was simply a sideshow as India's Afghanistan policy became aligned with that of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union (CPSU). Moscow's Afghan friends would be India's friends, and Moscow's enemies in Afghanistan, if not enemies shall neither be India's friends.

The CPSU's pro-Parcham tilt allowed New Delhi to widen engagement with Karmal and later with Najibullah, but alienated it from other bodies of political opinion on the Afghan landscape. Not surprisingly, neither the people of Afghanistan, nor the Parcham-dominated Kabul government was completely satisfied with India's response (a theme that would dominate India's engagement with Afghanistan in the following decades). For Afghan president Karmal and PM Shah Mohammad Dost, who had welcomed Brajesh Mishra's UN speech and Jaskaran Teja's private reassurances, India's abstention in the subsequent UN